

BETTER VICE CLUB

Learn.WitUS Curriculum

CentenarianOS Academy

Episode 1

Coffee

"The Morning Ritual"

Social Studies

Teacher Curriculum Packet

High School Pilot | 2025-2026

How Better Vice Club Works

Better Vice Club (BVC) is a podcast curriculum that teaches Geography, Social Studies, Economics, and English Language Arts through global commodities. Each episode follows a single substance from its geographic origin through its history, economics, and the literature it generated. Your packet isolates your subject so you can use it standalone, or coordinate with other departments for a full interdisciplinary unit.

What You Need

- Episode audio linked on the Episode Overview page. Episodes run 35 to 40 minutes. You can use the full episode or specific segments called CUT POINTS.
- This packet. All student-facing materials are here, ready to print or share digitally.
- No additional materials required for the core activities.

CUT POINTS

Each episode is divided into labeled segments. You do not need to play the full episode. CUT-1D is the Economics segment; CUT-1E is ELA, and so on. Start times are on the Episode Overview page.

The Four BVC Patterns

These four patterns repeat across all three seasons of BVC, covering 21 episodes. Each subject connects to the patterns most relevant to that discipline:

- Geography Insists. The physical landscape determines what can grow and how it tastes.
- Cultivation Begins Sacred. Most commodities begin as ceremonial practice before they become commercial products.
- Labor Captures the Smallest Share. Producers earn the least. Brands and retailers earn the most.

- What Gets Burned, What Gets Saved. Who controls the narrative about a commodity shapes its history.

BVC is produced by Anthony McDonald in Indianapolis, Indiana. All content is documented with peer-reviewed APA citations. No fabricated stories or unnamed expert characters appear in any episode. The curriculum brand is Learn.WitUS, hosted at CentenarianOS.com/academy.

Episode 1 Overview: Coffee

Detail	Information
Episode title	The Morning Ritual
Season	Season 1: Daily Rituals
Full runtime	35 to 40 minutes
Subjects	Geography, Social Studies, Economics, ELA (all four in one episode)
Audio access	CentenarianOS.com/academy or ask your BVC contact for the file
Recommended grade	9 to 12 (Indiana Academic Standards aligned)

Segment Map

Use CUT POINTS to navigate directly to your subject without playing the full episode.

Cut ID	Segment Title	Start Time	Duration	Subject
CUT-1A	Cold Open: A Cup of Questions	0:00	2 min	All subjects
CUT-1B	The Bean Belt	2:00	8 min	Geography
CUT-1C	From Ethiopia to Empire	10:00	8 min	Social Studies
CUT-1D	What's in Your Cup?	18:00	8 min	Economics
CUT-1E	Stories in Every Cup	26:00	8 min	ELA
CUT-1F	The Conscious Cup (Closing)	34:00	2 min	All subjects

Episode Summary

Episode 1 follows coffee from the volcanic highlands of Ethiopia through the colonial trade routes that spread it globally, to the supply chain economics that determine who earns what from the world's second-largest commodity market. Anthony McDonald opens with his morning routine in Indianapolis and traces the cup in his hand back through geography, history, economics, and literature.

Cross-curricular note: If colleagues in other departments are also piloting BVC, their students are studying the same episode through different lenses. The Season 2 finale (Episode 14) includes a cross-subject Pattern Wall activity that explicitly connects all four disciplines.

Social Studies Vocabulary

Introduce these terms before playing the Social Studies segment (CUT-1C, starting at 10:00).

Term	Definition	Episode Connection
Commodity	A raw material traded in large quantities on global markets.	Coffee as the world's second-largest commodity market after oil.
Colonialism	Control of one country's territory, economy, and people by a foreign power.	European powers spread coffee cultivation through their colonies.
Plantation economy	Large-scale agriculture using coerced or low-wage labor on a single crop.	Caribbean and Brazilian coffee slavery; modern low-wage farmworkers.
Coffeehouse	A 17th and 18th century gathering place for intellectual and political exchange.	London coffeehouses gave rise to newspapers, the stock market, and Lloyd's of London.
Sacred origin	BVC term for the pattern where commodities begin as ceremonial practice before commercialization.	Ethiopian Buna ceremony and Sufi devotional coffee use.
FPIC	Free, Prior, and Informed Consent. The UN standard for community approval before their knowledge is used commercially.	Coffee originates in Ethiopia but was spread by outside powers without community consent.
Supply chain inequity	The economic pattern where producers doing physical labor capture the smallest share of the final price.	Ethiopian farmer earns \$2 to \$3 per day for beans that retail at \$4 to \$5 per cup.
Mercantilism	Economic system where colonies exist to generate wealth for the home country through trade monopolies.	Dutch East India Company controlling the coffee trade from Java.

Social Studies Data Sheet: Coffee's History and Power

Selected Timeline

Date	Event	Significance
c. 850 CE	Kaldi legend: Ethiopian goatherd discovers coffee	Documents Ethiopian origin; the earliest known human-coffee relationship is preserved in oral tradition.
1454	First documented coffee use in Sufi monasteries, Yemen	Coffee begins as sacred practice: monks drink it to sustain overnight prayer, not for pleasure.
1475	World's first coffeehouse opens in Constantinople (Istanbul)	Coffee creates a social institution before it becomes a commercial commodity.
1652	First English coffeehouse opens in London (opened by Pasqua Rosee, a Greek immigrant)	Newspapers, stock trading, and intellectual exchange originate in coffeehouses.
1675	Charles II tries to suppress coffeehouses across England	Government fears political dissent. The proclamation is withdrawn 11 days later under merchant pressure.
1688	Edward Lloyd's Coffee House becomes a marine insurance market	Direct ancestor of Lloyd's of London, now a \$40 trillion global insurance institution.
1727	First coffee planted in Brazil (from a smuggled plant)	Beginning of Brazilian dominance: Brazil now produces 38 percent of global supply.
1788	Saint-Domingue (Haiti) supplies 50 percent of world's coffee	Built entirely on enslaved labor. The Haitian Revolution of 1791 was partly a direct response.

1791 to 1804	Haitian Revolution: enslaved people abolish slavery	Coffee wealth funded the revolution that produced the world's first Black republic.
2024	Ethiopian farmers earn \$2 to \$3 per day; a cafe cup retails at \$4 to \$5	The colonial-era economic structure is unchanged in its basic outcome.

Primary Source: Pasqua Rosee's Coffee Advertisement (London, 1652)

The Vertue of the COFFEE Drink. First publiquely made and sold in England, by Pasqua Rosee...

"It will prevent drowsiness and make one fit for business. It is excellent to prevent and cure the dropsy, gout and scurvy, as well as scrofula, miscarriages and a most excellent remedy against the spleen, hypocondriack winds and the like."

-- Printed handbill distributed in London, 1652

Context: Rosee was a Greek immigrant from Istanbul marketing a culturally unfamiliar drink to a skeptical English public. He uses medical claims to make coffee appear respectable and professionally useful.

Primary Source: Charles II's Proclamation Against Coffeehouses (1675)

"His Majesty doth hereby Prohibit all persons from keeping any Coffee House... Coffee houses have produced very evil and dangerous effects; as well for that many tradesmen and others do therein misspend much of their time, which might and probably would otherwise be employed in and about their lawful calling and affairs."

-- Royal Proclamation, 1675 (withdrawn 11 days later under merchant pressure)

Historical note: Charles II was alarmed that coffeehouses enabled political dissent, pamphlet-reading, and organized opposition. The language of misspent

time conceals what the actual concern was.

Indiana connection: Indianapolis has a significant Ethiopian-American community. The Ethiopian Buna coffee ceremony, documented as a living cultural tradition, is practiced in Indianapolis homes today. The same plant whose colonial trade history is documented above is part of the current fabric of Indianapolis's East African community life.

Social Studies Activity: The Sacred-to-Commercial Pattern

Time: 35 to 40 minutes. Materials: this packet plus the primary source excerpts above.

Step 1: Sacred Origins (10 minutes)

Before coffeehouses and commodity markets, coffee was a spiritual practice.

- Sufi monks in 15th century Yemen drank coffee to sustain overnight prayer and meditation. The first documented use is religious, not recreational.
- The Ethiopian Buna ceremony involves incense, grass, and three rounds of brewing. It is a living ritual still practiced in Ethiopian-American communities in Indianapolis.

Discussion: What was coffee before it was a commercial product? What does this tell us about BVC's Sacred-to-Commercial pattern?

Step 2: Political Suppression (10 minutes)

Using Charles II's 1675 proclamation and the coffeehouse history, students work through these questions:

- The proclamation says coffeehouses cause evil effects from misspent time. What does the historical context suggest the real concern was?
- The proclamation was withdrawn after 11 days because merchants protested. What does this tell us about the economic power of coffee culture by 1675?
- Compare this strategy (framing political suppression as a productivity concern) to any current example where you think the stated reason for a policy differs from the actual reason.

Step 3: Then and Now (10 minutes)

- In 1788, Haiti produced 50 percent of the world's coffee on slave-worked plantations. Today, Ethiopian farm workers earn \$2 to \$3 per day. Is the economic

structure fundamentally different, or has only the legal status of labor changed?
What evidence would you need to answer this confidently?

Discussion Questions

- Does coffee's history fit BVC's Sacred-to-Commercial pattern? What stage of the pattern is the global coffee industry in today?
- Charles II suppressed coffeehouses because they enabled political organizing. Can you identify a current example where a gathering space or platform has been restricted for political reasons framed as something else?

Social Studies Knowledge Checks

Use as an exit ticket, short quiz, or discussion prompt. Answer key follows.

1. What was coffee's original cultural use before it became a commercial commodity? Cite at least one specific historical example from the timeline with a date.

2. Charles II's 1675 proclamation stated that coffeehouses caused evil effects from misspent time. Using historical evidence, explain what the real political concern was, and what the language of misspent time reveals about how governments can frame suppression of political activity.

3. Haiti supplied 50 percent of the world's coffee in 1788, all produced by enslaved labor. Ethiopian farmers today earn \$2 to \$3 per day while a cafe cup retails at \$4 to \$5. In three to four sentences: what has changed in the global coffee economy since 1788, and what has not changed?

Answer Key (teacher reference only)

Q1 expected answer:

Sufi monks in Yemen used coffee to sustain overnight religious observance (first documented use: 1454). This is explicitly spiritual, not recreational. The Ethiopian Buna ceremony is a second acceptable example. Students must cite a specific date from the timeline.

Q2 expected answer:

Coffeehouses were where people read political pamphlets, criticized the government, and organized opposition. The misspent time language frames this political threat as a productivity concern, making suppression sound neutral and managerial rather than political. This avoids legitimizing the opposition by naming it as a political force. Students should explicitly name the gap between stated and actual concern.

Q3 expected answer:

What has changed: slavery is abolished; labor is legally paid; production geography has shifted (Brazil dominant, not Haiti). What has NOT changed: the proportion of final retail price captured by producing-country farmers remains very small (roughly 2 to 6 percent of retail). Economic value still concentrates at the consumption end. The colonial model's outcomes persist through market structure rather than legal coercion.

Indiana Social Studies Standards Alignment

Standard	Description	Where Addressed
WH.4.1	Analyze causes and effects of European colonialism	Coffee's colonial expansion timeline; Dutch East India Company; Brazilian coffee slavery
WH.4.3	Evaluate the impact of the Transatlantic Slave Trade	Haitian coffee production; plantation slavery; the 1791 revolution
USH.2.3	Analyze the development of global trade networks	Coffee supply chain from Ethiopia and Yemen through Europe to the Americas
C&G.2.1	Analyze how economic interests shape government policy	Charles II's coffeehouse suppression; trade monopoly protection
WH.5.4	Evaluate how globalization affects cultural and economic systems	Ethiopian Buna ceremony alongside the global coffee commodity market

Reviewer's Feedback Form

Your feedback directly shapes the Learn.WitUS curriculum. Please complete this form after using the materials with students.

DIGITAL VERSION: Scan the QR code below or visit the link provided by your BVC contact. Responses feed directly into a shared spreadsheet for curriculum improvement.

[QR CODE]

About You

1. Subject you teach:

2. Grade level(s) in this pilot:

3. Approximate number of students who used this material:

About the Materials

4. Which segment(s) or activities did you use?

5. Did students have sufficient background knowledge to engage? What was missing or helpful?

6. Were the Indiana Standards alignments accurate for how you teach this standard?

Student Engagement

7. Scale 1 to 5: How well did the episode hold student attention? (1 = struggled, 5 = highly engaged) Notes:

8. What specific activity or discussion moment generated the most student response?

Usability

9. Would you use this as a standalone lesson, a unit anchor, or a recurring series? Why?

10. The single change that would make this most usable in your classroom next fall:

Overall

11. Would you recommend this curriculum to a colleague? What would you say?

Responses are confidential and used only to improve Learn.WitUS curriculum. Thank you for your time and expertise. Anthony McDonald, Better Vice Club